

JAMES

THE

CATHOLIC EPISTLE OF S. JAMES,

THE APOSTLE.

ON THE CATHOLIC EPISTLES.

PREFACE.

The seven following Epistles have been called Catholic or general, not being addressed to any particular Church or person, if we except the Second and Third of S. John. They are called also Canonical, having been received by the Church as part of the canon of the New Testament, and as writings of divine authority. It is a matter of fact allowed by every one, that five of these epistles, to wit, this of S. James, the Second of S. Peter, the Second and Third of S.

John, that of S. Jude, as also the Epistle of S. Paul to the Hebrews, and the Apocalypse or Revelation of S. John, were doubted of, and not received always and every where in the three first ages, till the canon and catalogue of Scripture books was examined by tradition, and determined by the authority of the Catholic Church, the supreme judge of all controversies in matters of faith and religion, according to the appointment of our Saviour, Christ, expressed in many places in the holy Scriptures. But I could never learn upon what grounds they who deny the Catholic Church and General Councils to be of an infallible authority, and who deny Christ's promises to guide his Church in all truth to the end of the world, can be certain which Scriptures or writings are canonical, and which are not. I could never understand what construction to put on the sixth of the Thirty-nine Articles of Religion of the Church of England. We there meet with this declaration: In, or by the name of the holy Scripture, we understand those canonical books of the Old and New Testament of whose authority was never any doubt in the Church. These I have mentioned were certainly for some time doubted of; they are still doubted of by some of the late reformers: Luther, the great doctor of the reformation, is not ashamed to say that this epistle of S. James is no better than straw, and unworthy of an apostle. These writings therefore, according to the said declaration, ought not to be accounted and received as canonical; and yet before the end of the said sixth article, it is again declared, that all the books of the Old and New Testament, as they are commonly received, we do receive and account canonical. And in all New Testaments of the Church of England, all these are received for

canonical in the same manner as the four gospels, without any remark or advertisement to the contrary. — The first of the seven epistles was written by S. James, surnamed the lesser, and James of Alpheus, (Mat. x. 3.) one of the twelve apostles, called the brother of our Lord, (Gal. i. 19.) who was made bishop of Jerusalem. His mother is thought to have been Mary, sister to the blessed Virgin Mary, and to have been married first to Alpheus, and afterwards to Cleophas; to have had four sons, James, Joseph, Simon, (or Simeon) and Jude, the author of the last of these epistles. All these four being cousins-german, are called brothers of our Lord, Mat. xiii. 55. How great a veneration the Jews themselves had for this apostle and bishop of Jerusalem, see not only Hegisippus apud Euseb. l. ii. hist. c. 23. and S. Jer. de viris illustribus, also the same S. Jer. in Gal. i. 19. (tom. iv, p. 237, l. 1. cont. Jovin.

tom. iv, part 2, p. 182.) but even Josephus, (l. xxviii. Antiq. c. 8.) where he calls him the brother of Jesus, surnamed the Christ. This epistle was written about the year 62. The chief contents are: 1. To shew that faith without good works will not save a man, as S. Aug. observed, l. de fid. et oper. c. iv.; 2. He exhorts them to patience, to beg true wisdom, and the divine grace; 3. He condemns the vices of the tongue; 4. He gives admonitions against pride, vanity, ambition, &c.; 5. To resist their disorderly lusts and desires, which are the occasions and causes of sin, and not Almighty God; 6. He publisheth the sacrament of anointing the sick with oil; 7. He recommends prayer, &c. S.

Jerom, in a letter to Paulinus, (t. iv. part 2, p. 574.) recommends all these seven epistles in these words: James, Peter, John, and Jude, published seven epistles . . . both short and long, short in words, long as to the content; Jacobus, Petrus, Joannes, Judas, septem epistolas ediderunt . . . breves pariter et longas, breves in verbis, longas in sentiis. Wi. — S. Gregory Nazianzen remarks, that the faithful were not agreed as to the number of these epistles; some admitted seven and some only three, viz. this of S. James, the first of S. John, and the first of S. Peter:

Katholikon Epistolon

Tines men epta phasin, oi de treis monas

Chrenai dechesthai ten Iakobou mian,

Mian de Petrou, tente Ioannou mian. — Naz. Carm. de Script. Canon.

We shall state at the beginning of each epistle, the reason why they have been adopted into the canon of Scripture. C. — The object of these epistles was, according to the remark of S. Augustine, to refute the rising errors of Simon Magus, the Nicolaites, and other such heretics, who abusing the liberty of the gospel, and perverting the meaning of S. Paul's words in his epistle to the Romans, pretended that faith alone, without good works, was sufficient for salvation; although S. Paul expressly requires Christians, a faith working by charity, Gal. v. 6. and 1 Cor. xiii. where he uses these emphatic words: "If I should have all faith, so as to remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing." S. Aug. lib. de fide et operibus, c. xiv. C. — As to what regards the authenticity of S. James' epistle, although Luther with his usual boldness asserts that many with good reason denied this epistle to be canonical, and affirmed that it was unworthy the pen of an apostle, yet, admitting that some individuals in the first ages of the Church doubted of its authority, we are nevertheless assured from certain monuments that it was always considered as sacred and inspired both by the Latin and Greek Churches. This is evident from the sixtieth canon of the council of Laodicea; from the forty-seventh of the council of Carthage, in 397; from Origen, hom. vii. in Josue; from S.

Athanasius in synopsi, Epiphanius hæresi 76; from S. Jerom, ad Paulinum Epis.; from S. Austin, lib. ii. de Doc. Chris. c. viii; from S. Gregory Nazianzen, tom. iii, p. 98; from Amphilochus, apud Greg. Nazian. tom. ii. p. 194; from Innocent I. Epis. ad Decentium; from Rufinus, Exposit. Symboli; and from Gelasius I. who in the fifth age, in a council of seventy bishops, at Rome, settled the canon of the genuine

books of the holy Scripture, and distinguished them from what are spurious. Cal. et Habert de Sacr. Ext. Un. —

S. Jerom and S. Austin quote frequently this epistle as the undoubted work of this apostle; and since their time, its authenticity has never been called in question by Catholics. It is believed S. James wrote this epistle in Greek, as he quotes the Scripture according to the version of the Septuagint, as C. iv. 6; and as this language was commonly spoken in the East by the dispersed Jews, to whom he wrote. his style is concise and sententious, like that of Solomon in his proverbs, and like the maxims of the Orientals even to the present day. C.

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JAMES 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. James, a servant of God, and of our Lord Jesus Christ. Some have doubted whether the author of this epistle was S. James, the apostle, because he does not call himself an apostle. By the same weak argument we might reject all the three epistles of S. John and his Apocalypse, and the epistle of S.

Jude. Nor does S. Paul give himself this title in those to the Thessalonians, to the Philippians, to Philemon, or to the Hebrews. — To the twelve tribes, which are dispersed. Lit. which are in the dispersion. That is, to the Jews converted in all nations. — Greetings. [1] Lit. salvation. Which comprehendeth much the same as, when S. Paul says, grace, peace, mercy, &c. Wi.

Ver. 2. Into divers temptations. The word temptations, in this epistle, is sometimes taken for trials by afflictions or persecutions, as in this place; sometimes for a tempting, enticing, or drawing others into sin. Wi.

Ver. 3-4. The trying of your faith worketh patience. S. Paul seems to assert the reverse: (v. 3.) when he says, patience worketh a trial. They are easily reconciled. Here S. James teacheth us, that patience is occasionally obtained, and strengthened by sufferings, the meaning of S. Paul is, that patience worketh, sheweth itself, and is found perfect in the sight of God by trials. Wi.

Ver. 5. And upbraideth not. That is, God does not think much, nor reproach us with the multitude of his benefits and favours: and if he puts sinners in mind of their repeated ingratitude, it is for their good and conversion. Wi.

Ver. 7. Let not that man think that he shall receive. He that has not a lively faith and firm hope, wavering with a distrust of God's power or goodness, must not imagine to receive what he so faintly asks. Wi.

Ver. 8. Such a one, is as it were a double-minded man,[2] divided betwixt God and the world, halting betwixt two, and becomes inconstant in all his ways, always rising and falling, beginning and relapsing. Wi.

Ver. 9-12. The brother of low condition. Lit. humble.[3] See Luke i. 48. The sense is, that a Christian, of never so low and poor a condition, may glory, and rejoice even in his poverty, that he is not only the servant, but even the adoptive son of God. But the rich, in his being low. Some word must be here understood to make the sense complete. If we understand, let the rich man glory, it must be expounded by irony, by what follows, of his passing away like a flower. But others rather understand some other word of a different signification; as, let the rich man lament the low condition that he must come to; for he must quickly fade away like grass. — The beauty of the shape thereof[4] perished. So the Hebrews say, the face of the heavens, the face of the earth, &c. Wi.

Ver. 13. God is not a tempter[5] of evils, and he tempteth no man. Here to tempt, is to draw and entice another to the evil of sin, which God cannot do.

The Greek may also signify, he neither can be tempted, nor tempt any one. But every one is thus tempted by the evil desires of his corrupt nature, which is called concupiscence, and which is not properly called a sin of itself, but only when we yield to it. Wi.

Ver. 15. When concupiscence hath conceived, (man's free will yielding to it) it bringeth[6] forth sin, our perverse inclinations become sinful, and when any grievous sin is completed, or even consented to, it begetteth death, it maketh the soul guilty of eternal death. It may not be amiss here to observe with S.

Gregory, &c. that there are three degrees in temptations: the first, by suggestion only; the second, by delectation; the third, by consent. The first, the devil, or our own frail nature, tempts us by a suggestion of evil thoughts in our imagination: to have such thoughts and imaginations may be no sin at all, though the things and objects represented be never

so foul and hideous, though they may continue never so long, and return never so often. The reason is, because we cannot hinder them. On the contrary, if our will remains displeased with them, and resist them, such a resistance is meritorious, and by the mercies of God will purchase us a reward. Second, these representations may be followed with a delight or delectation in the senses, or in the body only; and if by an impression made against the will, which we no ways consent to, there is again no sin. There may be also some neglect in the person tempted, by not using sufficient endeavours to resist and repel those thoughts, which if it be only some small neglect, the sin is not great: but if the person tempted hath wilfully, and with full deliberation, taken delight in evil thoughts, either of revenge, or of fornication, or adultery, or about any thing very sinful, such a wilful delight is a grievous and deadly sin, though he hath not had a will or design to perform the action itself. The reason is, because he then wilfully consents in mind and heart to a sinful delight, though not to the execution or action. And the sin may be great, and mortal, though it be but for a short time: for a temptation may continue for a long time and be no sin; and there may be a great sin in a short time. The reason again is, because we are to judge of sin by the dispositions and consent of the will, not by the length of time. Third, when the sinner yields to evil suggestions and temptations, so that his will fully consents to what is proposed, and nothing can be said to be wanting but an opportunity of putting his sinful desires in execution, he has already committed the sin; for example, of murder, of fornication, &c. in his heart, as our blessed Saviour taught us. Mat. v. 28. Wi.

Ver. 16-17. Do not err, nor deceive yourselves by yielding to temptation; beg God his supporting grace, for every good gift is from him. Wi.

Ver. 18. By the word of truth. Some, with S. Athanasius, understand the eternal word made man. Others commonly understand the word of the gospel, by which we have been called to the true faith, &c. — Some beginning^[7] of his creatures, (or as the Greek signifies) such a beginning as are the first-fruits; and perhaps S. James may so call the Jews, as being the first converted to believe in Christ. Wi.

Ver. 19. You know, or you are sufficiently instructed in these things. — Let every man be swift to hear the word of God, but slow, or cautious in speaking, especially slow to anger, or to that rash passion of anger, which is never excusable, unless it be through a zeal for God's honour, and against sin. Wi. —

S. James in this epistle does not aim at a regular discourse: he proposes a diversity of moral sentences, which have not much connection with each other. He here instructs the faithful how to behave in conversation. He recommends to them modesty and prudence in their discourses; and rather to be fond of hearing much, than of speaking much; and of practising the truth, than of preaching it to others. "For not those who understand the law, nor those who preach it, are justified before God, but the doers of the law shall be justified before God." Rom. c. ii. 13. C. — A wise man is known by the fewness of his words. *Sapiens verbis innotescit paucis.* Regl. S. Ben. c. vii. With hearing, the wise man will become wiser. Sen. lib. ii. de Irâ. c. 28. — Anger is a short madness. The best cure is to permit it to subside, and to let our reason have time to reflect upon the propriety of doing what we are at first inclined to.

The first motions to anger are frequently indeliberate, and consequently not sinful; but we must be careful to resist as soon as we perceive them, lest they should become too violent, and obtain the consent of our will. C. — Learn of me, says our Saviour, because I am meek and humble of heart. Mat c. xii. 29. If, says S. Francis de Sales, being stung and bit by detractors and enemies, we fly out, swell, and are enraged, it is a great sign that neither our humility nor meekness are true and sincere, but only apparent and artificial. It is better, says S. Austin, writing to Profuturus, to deny entrance to just and reasonable anger, than to admit it, be it ever so little; because, being once admitted, it is with difficulty driven out again; for it enters as a little twig, and in a moment becomes a beam: and if it can once but get the night of us, and the sun set upon it, which the apostle forbids, it turns into a hatred, from which we have scarcely any means to rid ourselves; for it nourishes itself under a thousand false pretexts, since

**there was never an angry man that thought his anger unjust.
Introduction to a devout life, p. 3. c. viii.**

Ver. 20. The anger of man, &c. Let us not then be angry with each other on the way to eternal life, but rather march on with the troop of our companions and brethren meekly, peaceably, and lovingly; nay, I say to you absolutely and without exception, be not angry at all, if it be possible, and admit no pretext whatsoever to open the gate of your heart to so destructive a passion: for S.

James here tells us positively, and without reservation, "the anger of man works not the justice of God." S. Francis, ibidem. — The patient man is better than the valiant; and he that ruleth his spirit, than he that taketh cities. Prov. c.

xvi. 32. The anger of man is the daughter of pride, the mother of enmities, he enemy of peace and harmony, and the source of stubbornness and blindness of mind and heart. The justice of God is humility, meekness, charity, peace, docility, and forbearance. How great the contrast!

Ver. 21. All uncleanness.[8] The Greek shews that hereby is meant a sordid, filthy uncleanness, infecting and defiling the soul. — The engrafted[9] word.

The word and doctrine of Christ, by the labours of his preachers, and chiefly by his divine grace engrafted and fixed in your souls. Wi.

Ver. 23. He shall be compared to a man, &c. The sense is, that it is not enough for a man to examine and look into his interior, and the state of his conscience in a negligent and superficial manner, no more than one that goes to a looking-glass, but does not take care to take away the dirt or spots which he might discover. Wi.

Ver. 25. The law of Christ, called here the perfect law of liberty, as it is distinguished from the Jewish law of fear and slavery, is as it were a looking-glass, which may make us know ourselves, and discover and correct our failings. Wi.

Ver. 26. If any man think, &c. He here blames those hot disputes, which seem to have been frequent amongst the converted Jews, concerning the necessity of observing the legal rites. In vain, says he, do you pique yourselves upon the rigorous observance of the law, and your zeal to unite its ceremonial rites with the practice of the gospel. If you be void of the essence of Christianity, which is charity, prudence, and moderation, your religion will avail you nothing. C. —

This may also be understood of those devotees who are fond of making a parade of their virtues, and who, as S. Gregory says, (hom. xii. in Mat.) afflict their bodies indeed with fasting, but for this they expect to be esteemed by men. A. — A man must not imagine himself to be religious, and perfect in the way of virtue, unless he governs and bridles his tongue from oaths, curses, calumnies, detractions, lies, of which more in the third chapter. Wi.

Ver. 27. Religion pure and unspotted, &c. S. James may use the word pure, as a proper admonition to the Jews, who were generally mostly solicitous to avoid legal uncleanness, such as were incurred by eating meats forbidden in their law as unclean, by touching a dead body, &c. He therefore tells them that the Christian religion is known by acts of charity, by visiting and assisting widows, the fatherless, and such as are under afflictions, and in general by keeping our consciences interiorly clean, unspotted, and undefiled from this world, from the corrupt maxims and sinful practices so common in this wicked world. Wi.

[1] V. 1. Salutem, chairein, salvari, salvos esse.

[2] V. 8. Duplex animo, aner dipsuchos, quasi habens duas animas, dubius, incertus, potius quam hypocrita.

[3] V. 9. Humilis, and in humilitate, tapeinos, tapeinosei. See Luke i. 48.

[4] V. 11. Decor vultus ejus, euprepeia tou prosopou; the Hebrews say, faciem, cœli, terræ, gladii, &c.

[5] V. 13. Deus enim intentator, i.e. non tentator; by the Greek, apeirastos; which may signify intentabilis, qui non potest tentari.

[6] V. 15. Generat mortem, apokuei thanaton; apokuein is fætum emittere, and generare, as it is also here again used v. 18.

[7] V. 18. Initium aliquod creaturæ ejus, aparchen tina. See Rom. xi. 16. 1 Cor.

xv. 20. and xvi. 15. &c.

[8] V. 21. Immunditiam, ruparian, from rupos, sordes, spurcitia.

[9] Ibid. Insitum verbum, emphuton logon.

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JAMES 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. With respect of persons. This partial respect of persons is several times condemned both in the Old and New Testament. S. James here speaks of it as it was committed in the assemblies, by which many understand the meetings of Christians, in[1] synagogues and places where they celebrated the divine service, or met to keep the charitable feast, called Agape. Others expound it of meetings where causes were judged. If it be meant of Church meetings, the apostle might have even greater reason to condemn such a partiality at that time than at present; for when the poorer sort of people, of which was the greatest number of converts, saw themselves so neglected and despised, and any rich man when he came thither so caressed and honoured, this might prove a discouragement to the meaner sort of people, and an obstacle to their conversion. But if we expound it of meetings where causes were judged betwixt the rich and others of a lower condition, (which exposition the text seems to favour) the fault might be still greater, when the judges gave sentence in favour of great and rich men, biassed thereunto by the unjust regard they had for men rich and powerful. This was a transgression of the law: (Lev. xix. 15.) Respect not the person of the poor, nor honour the countenance of the mighty. But judge thy neighbour according to justice. See also Deut. i. 17. Wi. — Respect, &c. The meaning is, that in matters relating to faith, the administering of the sacraments and other spiritual functions in God's Church, there should be no respect of persons: but that the souls of the poor should be as much regarded as those of the rich. C. i. 17. Ch.

Ver. 4. Are become judges of (or with) unjust thoughts,[2] when against justice you favour the rich. Or, if in Church assemblies you discover a wrong and partial judgment in your minds and thoughts, by the high value and esteem you shew to the rich on account of their riches, and the contempt you have of poverty and of the poor, when they are perhaps more deserving in the sight of God, who hath chosen them who are rich in faith, whom he hath made his adoptive children, and heirs of his kingdom. These are much the greater riches: this is a dignity far surpassing that of the greatest king or emperor. And you

have less reason to shew such distinguishing marks of honour and esteem for the rich of this world, since it is they who by might and violence oppress you, draw you to judgment-seats: and they are less worthy of your honour and esteem, when by their scandalous behaviour they blaspheme, or cause to be blasphemed and ill-spoken of, the good and holy name of God, which is invoked upon you. Wi.

Ver. 8. If then you fulfil the royal law, . . . thou shalt love, &c. you do well. By these words, the apostle explains what he had said before of the particular respect paid to rich and powerful men, that if these were no more than some exterior marks paid them without any injustice or interior contempt of such as were poor, so that they took care to comply with that royal precept given to every one by Almighty God, the King of kings, thou shalt love thy neighbour, that is, every one without exception, as thyself; in this you do well; and the respect of persons was less blameable. Wi.

Ver. 10. Is become guilty of all. It is certain these words are not to be taken merely according to the letter, nor in the sense which at first they seem to represent, as if a man by transgressing one precept of the law transgressed and broke all the rest: this appears by the very next verse, that a man may commit murder by killing another, and not commit adultery. And it is certain, as S. Aug. observes, that all sins are not equal, as the Stoic philosophers pretended. See S. Aug. Epist. clxvii, (nov. ed. tom. 2, p. 595) where he consults S. Jerom on this very place out of S. James, and tells us that such a man may be said to be guilty of all, because by one deadly sin he acts against charity,[3]

(which is the love of God and of our neighbour) upon which depends the whole law and all its precepts; so that by breaking one precept, he loseth the habit of charity, and maketh the keeping, or not breaking of all the rest, unprofitable to him. Secondly, it may be added, that all the precepts of the law are to be considered as one total and entire law, and as it were a chain of precepts, where by breaking one link of this chain the whole chain is broken, or the integrity of the law, consisting of a collection of precepts. Thirdly, it may be said, that he who breaks any one precept, contemns the authority of the lawgiver, who enjoined them

all, and under pain of being for ever excluded from his sight and enjoyment. A sinner, therefore, by a grievous offence against any one precept, forfeits his heavenly inheritance, becomes liable to eternal punishments, as if he had transgressed all the rest: not but that the punishments in hell shall be greater against those who have been greater sinners, as greater shall be the reward in heaven for those who have lived with greater sanctity and perfection. Wi. — Guilty, &c. That is, he becomes a transgressor of the law in such a manner, that the observing of all other points will not avail him to salvation; for he despises the lawgiver, and breaks through the great and general commandment of charity, even by one mortal sin. Ch.

Ver. 12. By the law of liberty; i.e. by the new law and doctrine of Christ. Wi.

Ver. 13. For judgment without mercy, &c. It is an admonition to them to fulfil, as he said before, the royal precepts of the love of God and of our neighbour, which cannot be without being merciful to others. Blessed are the merciful, for they shall obtain mercy. Mat. v. 7. — And mercy exalteth itself above judgment.

Some understand this as a confirmation of God's infinite mercies, out of Ps.

cxliv. 9. where it is said that his "mercies are over all his works;" that is, though all his perfections be equally infinite, yet he is pleased to deal with sinners rather according to the multitude of his mercies than according to the rigour of his justice. Others expound these words of the mercy which men shew to one another, and that he exhorts them to mercy, as a most powerful means to find mercy; and the merciful works done to others will be beneficial to them, and make them escape when they come to judgment. Wi. — Similar to this are the words of old Tobias to his son: "Alms deliver from all sin, and from death, and will not suffer the soul to go into darkness. Alms shall be a great confidence before the most high God, to all them that give it." Tob. iv. 11, 12.

"Blessed are the merciful," says our divine Judge, "for they shall obtain mercy." Mat. v. 7. C. — And the definitive sentence of

Christians, at the day of judgment will be favourable or not, as they have complied in life with the calls of charity.

Ver. 14, &c. Shall faith be able to save him? He now comes to one of the chief points of this epistle, to shew against the disciple of Simon, the magician, that faith alone will not save any one. We may take notice in the first place, that S.

James in this very verse, supposes that a man may have faith, a true faith without good works. This also follows from v. 19. where he says: Thou believest that there is one God: thou dost well. And the same is evident by the words Jo. xii. 42. where it is said, that many of the chief men also believed in him, (Christ) . . . but did not confess it, that they might not be cast out of the synagogue. Now that faith alone is not sufficient to save a man, S. James declares by this example: If any one say to the poor and naked, go in peace, be you warmed and filled, and give them nothing, what shall it profit? Even so faith, if it have not works is dead, &c. i.e. such a faith, though it be not lost and destroyed, yet it remains in a soul that is spiritually dead, when it is not accompanied with charity and grace, which is the life of the soul, and without which faith can never bring us to eternal life. In this sense is to be understood the 20th and 26th verses of this chapter, when faith is again said to be dead without good works. This is also the doctrine of S. Paul, when he tells us that a saving faith is a faith that worketh by charity, Gal. v. 6. When he says, that although faith were strong enough to remove mountains, a man is nothing without charity. 1 Cor. xiii. 2. When he teacheth us again, that not the hearers of the law are just before God, but the doers of the law shall be justified. S.

John teacheth the same (1 Jo. iii. 14.) He that loveth not, remaineth in death.

But of this elsewhere. Wi. — Grotius in this place makes a very candid and remarkable profession of his faith, very different from that of his associates in the pretended reformation, called Solifideans: "There are some who say, 'My works indeed are not as they ought to be,' but my faith is firm, my salvation is therefore out of danger. This opinion, which has sprung up in this our unhappy age, and recommends itself

under the name of reformed doctrine, ought to be opposed by every lover of piety, and all who wish well to their neighbour's salvation no faith has ever availed any man, unless it were accompanied by such works as he had time and opportunity to perform." His words are:

"Opera quidem mea non recta sunt, sed fides recta est, ac propterea de salute non periclitor Renata est hoc infelici sæculo ea sententia et quidem sub nomine repurgatæ doctrinæ, cui omnes qui pietatem et salutem proximi amant, se debent opponere cæterum nulla cuiquam fides profuit, sine tali opere, quale tempus permittebat," &c. In vain do we glory in our faith, unless our lives and works bear testimony of the same. Faith without charity is dead, and charity cannot exist without good works. He who bears the fruits of Christian piety, shews that he has the root, which is faith; but the root is dead, when it affords no produce. Works are to faith what the soul is to the body. See the remainder of this chapter.

Ver. 18. Some men will say: Thou hast faith, and I have works. Shew me thy faith, &c. He confutes the same error, by putting them in mind that one can shew that he has faith, which is an interior virtue, only by good works, and that good works in a man shew also his faith; which is not to be understood, as if good works were merely the marks, signs, and effects of faith, as some would pretend, but that good works must concur with faith to a man's salvation by an increase in grace. Wi.

Ver. 19. The devils also believe, and tremble. S. James compares indeed faith without other virtues and good works, to the faith of devils: but comparisons must never be stretched farther than they are intended. The meaning is, that such a faith in sinners is unprofitable to salvation, like that of devils, which is no more than a conviction from their knowledge of God; but faith which remains in sinners, is from a supernatural knowledge, together with a pious motion in their free will. Wi.

Ver. 21. Was not Abraham . . . justified by works? We may observe, that S.

James here brings the very same examples of Abraham and Rahab, which it is likely he knew some had misconstrued in S. Paul, as if the great apostle of the Gentiles had taught that faith alone was sufficient to salvation. But S. Paul neither excludes good works done by faith, when he commends faith, excluding only the works of the law of Moses, as insufficient to a true justification. See Rom. iii. 27. And S. James by requiring good works does not exclude faith, but only teacheth that faith alone is not enough. This is what he clearly expresseth here in the 22d and in the 24th verse. Man, says he, is justified, and not by faith only. And (v. 22.) seest thou that faith did co-operate with Abraham's works, and by works faith was made perfect. In fine, we must take notice, that when S. James here brings the example of Abraham offering his son Isaac, to shew that he was justified by works, his meaning is not that Abraham then began first to be justified, but that he then received an increase of his justice. He was justified at least from his first being called, and began then to believe and to do good works. It is true his faith was made perfect, and his justice increased, when he was willing to sacrifice his son. Wi.

[1] V. 2. In conventum vestrum, eis ten sunagogen umon. Synagogue is also taken for a meeting of kings, judges, &c. See Mat. x. 17.

[2] V. 4. Judices cogitationum iniquarum: it is the same in the Greek, kritai dialogismon poneron: the sense is, Judices inique cogitantes.

[3] V. 10-11. S. Aug. Ep. lxxvii. num. 16. p. 600. An fortè quia plenitudo legis charitas est, qua Deus, proximusque diligitur, in quibus præceptis charitatis tota lex pendet et prophetæ, meritò fit reus omnium, qui contra illam facit ex qua pendent omnia.

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JAMES 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. But not many masters, teachers, and preachers. An admonition to all those who are not called, or not qualified to undertake this high ministry, lest they incur a greater condemnation. Wi.

Ver. 2. For in many things we all offend,[1] fall into many, at least failings. — If any man offend not in word, the same is a perfect man. He that in all occurrences can govern his tongue, has attained to a great degree of perfection. — He is able also with a bridle to lead about the whole body. He alludes to the comparison in the following verse; and the sense is, that when he has once perfectly subdued this unruly adversary, it may be presumed he can govern himself as to other passions, and the whole body of his actions.

Wi.

Ver. 3. If we put bits, &c. By the help of a bridle, a skillful rider can turn and guide horses never so headstrong and unruly. An experienced pilot sitting at the helm, steers the course of the vessel in a storm, turns and guides the ship what way he thinks most proper; so must a man learn, and use his utmost endeavours to bridle and govern his tongue. **Wi.**

Ver. 5-6. The tongue is indeed a little member, yet doth great things:[2] causeth great evils and mischiefs, when it is not carefully governed; as a little fire,[3] it kindleth and consumeth a great wood. It is a world of iniquity, the cause of infinite evils, dissensions, quarrels, seditions, wars, &c. It defileth the whole body, even the body politic of kingdoms. This fire, kindled by hell, sets all in a flame during the course of our lives, (lit. the wheel of our nativity) from our cradle to our grave. **Wi.**

Ver. 7. Is tamed, &c. The wildest beasts may be tamed, lions and tigers, and the rest,[4] and so managed as to do no harm. **Wi.**

Ver. 8. But the tongue no man can tame, without the special assistance of God.

Wi. — Wherefore we are to understand, says S. Austin, that as no one is able of himself to govern his tongue, we must fly to the Lord for his assistance. **S.**

Aug. ser. 4. de verb. Mat. vi. — It is an unquiet evil,[5] which cannot be stopt. It is full of deadly poison, which brings oftentimes death both to men's bodies and souls. **Wi.**

Ver. 9-13. By it we bless God, &c. Such different effects from the same cause, as of blessing God, and cursing men, created to the likeness of God, seem contrary to the ordinary course of nature; for a fountain from the same source doth not send forth both sweet and bitter streams. — Who is a wise man, and endued with knowledge among

you? &c. This seems to be connected with the admonition given at the beginning of the chapter, be not many masters; let none pretend to this but who have wisdom and knowledge, which also may be known by their prudent and mild conversation.

Ver. 14-16. But if you have bitter zeal. He hints at that bitter, false zeal, which many teachers among the Jews, even after their conversion, were apt to retain against the converted Gentiles, pretending with lies, and against the truth of the Scriptures, that they are not to be made partakers of the blessings brought to all nations by the Messias. — Glory not, boast not in this pretended wisdom, which descendeth not from above, from God, but which is earthly, sensual, diabolical, from an evil spirit, which foment these jealousies and divisions; and where there are such emulations and divisions, there is nothing but inconstancy, and all kind of evils. Wi.

Ver. 17-18. But the true wisdom, which is from above, . . . is chaste, and pure, peaceable, modest, free from such divisions, tractable, easy to be persuaded[6] of the truths foretold in the Scriptures, &c. Now the fruit and effect of such justice, piety, and sanctity, is sown in peace, with peaceable dispositions, in those who with sincerity seek true peace, and who hereby shall gain the reward of an eternal peace and happiness.

Wi. — S. Paul gives a similar character of charity. 1 Cor. c. xiii.

"Charity is patient, is kind, . . . is not ambitious, seeketh not her own, is not provoked to anger, thinketh no evil, . . .

believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things." — Easy to be persuaded. A good lesson for those devotees, who are not few in number, who are so obstinate and so wedded to their own opinions and ways, as to be unwilling to be controlled, even by those whom God has placed over them, for the direction of their souls. A. — Without judging. That is, it does not condemn a neighbour upon light grounds, or think evil of him. It puts the best construction upon every thing he says or does, and never intrudes itself into the concerns of others. C. — "Judge not, and you shall not be judged," says the Saviour of our souls; "condemn not, and you shall not be condemned." S.

Luke, vi. 37. "No," says the holy apostle, (1 Cor. iv. 5.) "judge not before the time until the Lord come, who both will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the counsels of the heart."

[1] V. 2. Offendimus, ptaïomen, we stumble, rather than fall.

[2] V. 5. Et magna exaltat, megalauchei; which is not only magnificè loqui et gloriari, but also magna facere.

[3] Ibid. Quantus ignis, for quantulus by the Greek, oligon pur.

[4] V. 7. Et cæterorum, by which the ancient interpreter had read ton allon, though in the present Greek copies we read, kai enalïon, et Marinorum.

[5] V. 8. Inquietum malum; so in divers Greek MSS. akatastaton, though in others, akatacheton, quod coerceri non potest.

[6] V. 17. Suadibilis, eupeithes; which may either signify easy to be persuaded or who can easily persuade.

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JAMES 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Whence are wars[1] and contentions, in all kinds, but from your lusts and disorderly passions, coveting to have and enjoy what you have not, as to pleasures, riches, honours, &c. Wi.

Ver. 2. You covet, and have not. Though God has promised that whosoever asks shall receive, (Mat. vii. 8.) yet no wonder you receive not, because you ask amiss, by asking such temporal things as would be prejudicial to your soul, or because you ask not with humility, devotion, and perseverance. Wi.

Ver. 4. Adulterers: which is here taken in a figurative sense for those who love creatures more than God, the true spouse of their souls; who reflect not that the love and friendship of this world is an enemy to God, and the true manner of serving him. Wi.

Ver. 5. Do you think that the scripture saith in vain: To envy doth the spirit covet, with dwelleth in you?[2] This verse is obscure, and differently expounded. By some, of an evil spirit in men, by which they covet and envy others for having what they have not. Others understand God's spirit inhabiting in them; and then it is an interrogation, and reprehension, as if he said: Doth God's spirit, which you have received, teach or excite you to covet and envy others, and not rather to love and wish their good? And to enable men to do this, God is not wanting, who gives us greater grace, especially to the humble that ask it, though he resists the proud. Wi. — It is not evident to what part of Scripture S. James here alludes, the exact words are nowhere in the sacred writings. That which seems the most like this text, and the most adapted to his subject, is a passage from Ezechiel, "I will set my jealousy against thee:" (Ezech. xxiii. 25.) i.e. I have loved thee with the love of jealousy, and I will revenge upon thee my slighted affections. C.

Ver. 6. But he giveth greater grace. The Holy Spirit which dwelleth in you, giveth you graces in proportion to your fidelity in complying with

them, and according to your humility and the love which you bear to your neighbour. C.

— S. James may also mean by these two verses, to exhort the Jews and Gentiles, who were rather jealous of each other, to nourish no jealousy against one another, nor be troubled at the blessing which their neighbour enjoyed from the bountiful hand of the Almighty. Then will God deal to us with a more liberal hand, and will bestow upon us greater graces in proportion as we lay aside all ill-will towards our neighbour. But that he will withhold his hand from the envious man, because he resists the proud, and gives his grace to the humble. Glory is the exclusive property of heaven; whoever, therefore assumes it to himself, makes God his enemy. There is nothing in man since his fall; there is nothing in holy writ which does not preach to us this truth. —

N.B. These last words, "God resisteth the proud, and giveth grace to the humble," are only in the Septuagint edition. Prov. iii. 34. The Heb. and Vulg.

read in this place, "He shall scorn the scorers, and to the meek he will give grace." C.

Ver. 7. Be subject therefore to God; humble yourselves in his sight, considering your own nothing. Wi.

Ver. 8. Purify your heart from the love of creatures, so that your affections be not divided betwixt God and this world, like persons of two minds[3] or two souls. Wi.

Ver. 9. Be afflicted[4] and mourn, and deplore your sins against his divine majesty; punish yourselves, and think not that a mere change of life is sufficient after so many sins committed. Wi.

Ver. 11. Detract not one another, (nor judge rashly) brethren. Though he spoke so much against the evils of the tongue, he gives them a special admonition against the vice of detraction, so common in the world, as also against rash judgments, which happen so frequently where there are dissensions and divisions. He that detracteth, judgeth, and rashly

condemneth his brother, may be said to detract and judge the law, inasmuch as he seems to condemn and condemn the law, by which these sins are forbidden; when, instead of obeying and complying with the law, he rather takes upon himself to act as a judge,[5]

without fear of the law and of God, the only lawgiver, who is to judge all our actions, and who alone is able to destroy, or to free us and deliver us from the punishments we have deserved. Wi.

Ver. 13. To-day or to-morrow, &c. An admonition against that presumption, when persons forget the uncertainty of life, and the vanity of all things in this world, which vanish like a vapour, and can never be relied upon, so as to count upon years and the time to come. All things here appear and disappear in a moment. Take heed, therefore, not to glory or boast in your arrogancies; (v.

16.) lit. pride; like the rich man, (Lu. x.) who thought of nothing but a long and merry life, and was cut off that very night. And being now admonished, reflect that it is sinful to know what is good, what is your duty, and not to comply with it. Wi.

Ver. 15. For what is your life? it is a vapour. We frequently meet with three beautiful comparisons in holy writ. "Remember that my life is but wind As a cloud is consumed, and passeth away; so he that shall go down to hell, shall not come up." Job vii. 7, 9. "Man is like to vanity, his days pass away like a shadow." Ps. cxliii. 4. Similar expressions also frequently occur in profane authors.

Nemo tam Divos habuit faventes

Crastinum ut possit sibi polliceri. Seneca.

With reason then did our Saviour say, "Be you then also ready, for at what hour you think not, the Son of Man will come." Lu. xii. 40. C.

[1] V. 1. Unde bella et lites? polemoi kai machai, as also v. 2, litigatis et belligeratis, machesthe, kai polemeite. I see no reason to translate it, by lawsuits and pleadings, as Mr. N.

[2] V. 5. Ad invidiam concupiscit Spiritus, qui habitat in vobis: pros phthonon epipothei to pneuma o katokesen (habitavit) en umin. Ven. Bede expounds it, nunquid Spiritus Gratiae . . . hoc concupiscit ut invideatis alterutrum?

[3] V. 8. Duplices animo, dipsuchoi.

[4] V. 9. Miseri estote, talaiporesate.

[5] V. 11. Parens . . . exterminabitur, phainomene, aphanizomene.

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JAMES 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1-6. Go now rich men, &c. In the first six verses, he gives admonitions to those among the Christians who were rich, not to rely on riches, nor value themselves on this account. You must look upon your riches and treasures as if they were already putrefied and corrupted, your gold and silver eaten and consumed with rust: and their rust shall rise in testimony and judgment against you, for not making better use of them. As your coin is eaten with rust, so shall your bodies be hereafter as it were eaten and consumed by fire. You heap up to yourselves a treasure in the day of wrath, while through covetousness, and hard heartedness, you defraud labourers of their hire, living at the same time in feasting and luxury, as in the day of slaughter. That is, feasting as men are accustomed to do, on the days when victims are slaughtered, offered, and eaten with great rejoicing. Others expound it, as if you were feeding, and making yourselves fit sacrifices and victims for God's anger and indignation. Wi. — You have feasted, &c. The Greek is, "you have lived in delicacies and debaucheries, and have feasted upon your hearts as for the day of sacrifice:" Etruphesate, kai espatalesate ethrepsate tas kardias umon os en emera sphages. That is, you have fattened yourselves with good cheer and sensual pleasures, like victims prepared for a solemn sacrifice. C. —

Others among you have unjustly oppressed, accused, and brought to condemnation the just one, by which seems to be understood just and innocent men, who are divers times deprived of their fortunes, and even of their lives, by the unjust contrivances of powerful wicked men. Wi.

Ver. 7-11. Be patient, &c. He now in these five following verses turns his discourse from the rich to the poor, exhorting them to patience till the coming of the Lord to judgment, which draweth near; his coming to judge every one is at his death. Imitate the patience of the husbandman, waiting for fruit after that the earth hath received the timely and early[1] rain soon after the corn is sown, and again more

rain, that comes later to fill the grain before it comes to be ripe. This seems to be the sense by the Greek: others expound it, till he receive the early and latter fruits. Wi. — Behold the judge standeth before the door. This expression is synonymous with that in the foregoing verse. "The coming of the Lord is at hand." This way of speaking is not uncommon in Scripture. Thus God said to Cain: "If thou hast done evil, shall not sin forthwith be present at the door?" S. James is here speaking of the approaching ruin of Jerusalem, the destruction of the temple, and the dispersion of the Jews by the Romans. C. — Call to mind for your encouragement the trials and constancy[2] of the prophets: the patience of Job, after which God rewarded him with great blessings and property, and you have seen the end of the Lord; that is, what end the Lord was pleased to give to Job's sufferings. But S. Aug.

Ven. Bede, &c. would have these words, the end of the Lord, to be understood of the death of our Lord Jesus Christ, on the cross, for which God exalted him,

&c. Wi.

Ver. 12. But above all things . . . swear not, &c. This earnest admonition is against all kind of oaths in common conversation, (not against oaths made on just and necessary occasions) and in the very same words, as our blessed Saviour warned all people against this sin of swearing. Mat. c. v. How unaccountably is this commandment of God contemned? And what a dreadful account will some day be exacted for so many oaths, curses, and blasphemies, which are now so common, that we may rather wonder at the patience of God and that already exemplary punishments have not fallen upon whole cities and kingdoms for this continued profanation of the holy name of God? Wi. — S. James here repeats the injunctions of our Saviour, not to swear at all. Mat. v. 34. See the annotations in that place.

Ver. 14-15. Is any man sick among you?[3] or in danger of death by sickness, let him call, or bring in the priests of the Church, &c. The apostle here enjoins the constant use of the sacrament, called extreme unction, or the last anointing with oil, instituted, (as were all the

sacraments of the Church) by our Saviour Christ, and which is here fully and clearly delivered in plain words, expressing, 1. the persons to whom this sacrament is to be administered; 2.

the minister; 3. the form; 4. the matter; 5. the effects. As to the first, is any man sick among you? This sacrament then is to be given to every believing Christian, who is in danger of death by sickness. 2. Bring in the priests, one or more, they are the ministers of this sacrament. The Protestant translation has the elders; yet in their book of common prayer, he who is called in to assist and pray with the sick, is called either the minister, the curate, or the priest, never the elder. Dr. Wells has not changed the word elders in his translation; but in his paraphrase he expounds it of those ministers of the church who are above deacons. 3. And let them pray over him. Besides other prayers, the form of this sacrament is by way of prayer, let the Lord forgive thee, &c. 4. Anointing him with oil. The oil with which he is anointed by the priest, is the outward visible sign, and the matter of this sacrament, as water is the matter of baptism. 5. And the prayer of faith shall save the sick man, &c. All the sacraments of the new law have their virtue from the merits of our Saviour, Christ, and therefore must be ministered and received with faith in our Redeemer. Wi. — Is any man sick? &c. The Greek expression in this place is equivalent to, "Is any one dangerously ill amongst you?" *Asthenei tis en umin.*

The primary intention of this sacrament of extreme unction, is to confer a special grace upon the dying Christian, to strengthen him in his last and dreadful conflict, when the prince of darkness will exert his utmost to ruin his poor soul. But besides this, it was also intended to free man from venial sin, and likewise from mortal, if guilty of any, provided he were contrite and not able to have recourse to the sacrament of penance. But the sacrament of penance being the only regular means of obtaining pardon for mortal sin committed after baptism, a person must first have recourse to this sacrament, if he be able, as a necessary preparation for the sacrament of extreme unction.

Other effects of this sacrament are, that it lessens the temporal punishment due to sin, and restores health to the worthy receiver, if it

be expedient for the good of his soul. S. Aug. serm. 215. C. Theol. Petav. Habert. Bailly, &c. de Extrem. Unct. — How great then is the folly of such persons as are afraid to receive this sacrament, imagining it to be the irrevocable sentence of impending dissolution? whereas one of the very effects of this sacrament is to restore health, if it be expedient for the soul; and who would wish for health upon any other conditions? A. — The anathemas pronounced by the council of Trent against those who deny the existence of this sacrament, are sufficient to establish the belief of it in the minds of Catholics. See sess. 14. can. 1. 2. and 3. of the council of Trent. It may be proper, however, to observe, in confirmation of our belief of this sacrament, that whenever the ancient Fathers have had occasion to speak of extreme unction, they have always attributed to it all the qualities of a sacrament, as S. Chrys. who proves from this text of S.

James the power which the priest has to forgive sins; (lib. 3. de Sacerdotio. S.

Aug. ser. 215) not to mention Origen, who wrote at the beginning of the third century, (hom. ii. in Levit.) enumerating the different ways by which sins are forgiven in the new law, says, "That they are remitted when the priests anoint the sick with oil, as is mentioned in S. James." When Decentius, bishop of Eugenium in Italy, in 416, wrote to Innocent I. upon this sacrament, he makes no question whether it was a sacrament, but only consults him concerning the manner of administering; whether a bishop could give it, or whether priests were the only administerers of this sacrament, as S. James says, "Let them call in the priests of the Church;" and whether it could be given to penitents before they had been reconciled by absolution. To the former question, the pope replied there could be no doubt, as S. James could never mean that bishops were excluded as being higher than priests; but that he supposed them to be taken up with other things. We might add to this, the word presbyter was then used indiscriminately for both bishops and priests. A. —

As to the next question, whether penitents could receive this sacrament before absolution, he answered in the negative. "For," says he, "can it

be thought that this one sacrament can be given to those who are declared unworthy of receiving the rest?" Innocent I. in epist. ad Decent. c. viii. Habert. de Extre.

Unct. — If it be objected that mention is not more frequently made of this sacrament in the writings of the ancients, we will answer with Bellarmin, that the most evident things were not always written, but only as occasion offered, that many of the mysteries were kept secret, to preserve them from the ridicule of the infidels. That in the times of persecution it was more difficult to administer this sacrament and less necessary, as the greatest part of Christians died not by sickness but by martyrdom. Theol. Petav. de Extre. Unc.

— Ven. Bede in Lu. ix. speaketh thus: "It is clear that this custom was delivered to the holy Church by the apostles themselves, that the sick should be anointed with oil consecrated by the bishop's blessing." — Let him bring in,

&c. See here a plain warrant of Scripture for the sacrament of extreme unction, that any controversy against its institution would be against the express words of the sacred text in the plainest terms. Ch. — And the Lord, by virtue of this sacrament, or if you will, sacramental prayer, shall raise him up, shall give him spiritual strength and vigour to resist the temptations which at that hour are most dangerous. He shall also raise him up, by restoring him his corporal health, when God sees it more expedient for the sick man. — And if he be in sins, they shall be forgiven him, not merely by prayer, but by this sacrament.

Wi.

Ver. 16. Confess, therefore, your sins, &c. Divers interpreters expound this of sacramental confession, though, as the authors of the annotations on the Rheims Testament observe, this is not certain. The words one to another, may signify that it is not enough to confess to God, but that we must also confess to men, and not to every man, but to those whom God appointed, and to whom he hath given the power of remitting sins in his name. I cannot but observe that no mention at all is made, "in the visitation and communion of the sick," in the Prot. common prayer book, of this comfortable passage out of S. James, of calling in the priests of the Church, of their anointing him with oil . . . and that his sins shall be forgiven him. Perhaps having laid aside that sacrament, it seemed to them better to say nothing of those words. But such a confession as is practised by all Catholics, is at least there advised. "The sick person,"

saith the book of common prayer, "here shall be moved to make a special confession of his sins . . . After which confession, the priest shall absolve him after this sort. Our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath left power to his Church to absolve all sinners, who truly repent, forgive thee . . . and by his authority committed to me, I absolve thee from all thy sins, in the name of the Father, "

&c. Here is a special confession, or a confession of particular sins; here is a power of forgiving sins in God's name, acknowledged to be given to the Church, and to priests; here are the very same words used by every Catholic priest in the sacrament of penance. This is clearly ordained in their liturgy: how far it is complied with, I know not. Wi. — One to another. That is, to the priests of the Church, whom (v. 14.) he had ordered to be called for, and brought in to the sick: moreover, to confess to persons who had no power to forgive sins, would be useless. Hence the precept here means that we must confess to men whom God hath appointed, and who, by their ordination and jurisdiction, have received the power of remitting sins in his name. Ch. — Pray for one

another. Here is recommended prayer in general, as a most necessary Christian duty. He encourages them to it by the example of Elias. Wi.

Ver. 20. He who causeth a sinner to be converted, &c. S. James concludes his epistle with a work of charity, one of the most acceptable to Almighty God, and most beneficial to our neighbour, when any one becomes instrumental in converting others from their errors, or from a wicked life; for it is only God that can convert the heart. But he who with a true and charitable zeal, animated with the love of God and of his neighbour, makes this the chief business of his life, has this comfort here given him, that this will cover in the sight of God a multitude of sins, which he may have contracted through human frailty. The Church of England, when they modelled the articles of their reformation, received this epistle of James as canonical. They profess to follow the holy Scriptures as the only rule of their belief: they find in the 14th and 15th verses of this chapter these words: "Is any man sick among you? Let him bring in the priests of the Church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil . . .

and if he be in sins, they shall be forgiven him." In these words they find all that they themselves require, to be a sacrament of the new law; to wit, a precept or injunction, clear and unlimited as to time, a visible sign, with a promise of invisible grace, in remitting of sins, the minister of it, and the persons specified who are to receive it. They also found this practised at the time of the reformation by the Universal Church, by all Catholics, both in the east and west, both by the Latin and by the Greek Churches; and that all Christian Churches received it as a sacrament; and yet they thought fit to lay it quite aside, as if it was neither a sacrament nor a holy ceremony, nor a pious custom fit to be retained. They must have judged that they had convincing proofs both to contradict in other things the judgment and belief of the Catholic Church, and also in this particular; as to which latter case, I shall examine the reasons which they bring. I presume it may be needless to insist upon the groundless imagination of Wycliff, and some heretics about that time, who denied this to be a sacrament, fancying it was prescribed by S.

James, because the oil of Palestine was a sovereign remedy to cure diseases.

If so, any physician, any old woman or nurse to the sick, might have applied oil full as well, if not better than the priests. Calvin, and the reformation writers, give us the following reasons or conjectures, that this anointing, as well as that, (Mark vi. 13.) was only to be used for a time, by those who had the gift of curing diseases miraculously; so that like other miraculous gifts, (as the speaking of tongues, prophesying, &c.) it was but to last during the first planting of the Christian faith. Dr. Fulk, against the Rheims Testament, and Mr.

Baxter, &c. affirm boldly, that Christ "appointed his apostles to anoint those with oil whom they cured." And Dr. Hammond says, "that the anointing with oil, was a ceremony used by Christ and his apostles in their miraculous cures."

They assert this, as if it was taught by Scripture itself. They are no less positive that this anointing soon ceased, and was laid aside with the gift of miraculous cures, given sometimes to the first Christians at their baptism, or when they received the Holy Ghost in the sacrament of confirmation. Dr. Fulk, besides this, is positive that "the Greek Church, never to this day received this anointing and praying over the sick as a sacrament." These are their arbitrary, groundless, and false expositions, which they bring against a clear text of the holy Scriptures. It might be sufficient to oppose the judgment and authority of the Church to their private judgment. But to answer in short each particular: we find by the evangelists, (Mat. x. 8. Mark vi. 13. Luke x. 9.) that Christ gave to his twelve apostles, and afterwards to his seventy-two disciples, in their first mission before his death, (which was only into the cities of Israel) a power of casting out devils, of raising the dead, of curing diseases in his name. And S.

Mark tells us, that they cast out many devils, and anointed many sick with oil, and cured them. But when Dr. Fulk and others add, that our Saviour appointed, ordered, or commanded them to anoint with oil those whom they cured, no such thing is said, nor insinuated, neither by S. Mark nor by any of the evangelists, nor any where in the holy

Scriptures. And how Dr. Hammond could tell us that this "anointing with oil was a ceremony used by Christ himself," I cannot imagine. As for the apostles and disciples, they might cure many, making use of oil, and many without it by laying hands upon them, by a prayer, or by calling upon the name of Jesus, as the seventy-two disciples returned to him with joy, (Luke x. 17.) saying, Lord, even the devils are subject to us in thy name. Neither is it judge probable by the interpreters that the apostles, in their miraculous cures, were tied up or confined to the use of oil: especially since we find that after Christ's resurrection, in their second mission to all nations, Christ foretells (Mat. xvi. 18.) that they who believe in him, shall have this miraculous gift of healing the sick, but mentions only the laying of hands upon them: they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall be well. Besides had Christ appointed or given orders to his disciples to make use of oil in such miraculous cures, it would scarce have happened but we should have some examples of it in the Acts of the Apostles, where so many miraculous cures are related to have been done by S. Peter, by S. Paul, and others, but no mention of this ceremony of oil. We agree with our adversaries that this gift of miraculous cures, of which S. Paul speaks, (1 Cor. xii.) was common only for a short time, like the other gifts of the Holy Ghost, which were only necessary, as S. Aug. takes notice, at the first planting of the Christian faith; and so that anointing with oil, merely as it was made use of in miraculous cures of the body, soon ceased, perhaps even before our Saviour's death; but we believe as our Saviour appointed water to be the matter of the sacrament of baptism, so he would have oil to be the matter of the sacrament of the sacrament of extreme unction, which he instituted to strengthen the souls of the sick, against the dangers and temptations at the approach of death, and of which S. James here speaks near upon thirty years after Christ's ascension. And the anointing in S. Mark, used in corporal diseases, may be looked upon as a figure of the sacrament of extreme unction in S. James, as the frequent washings or baptisms, as they are called, of the Jews, and especially the baptism of S. John, was a figure of the baptism of Christ. The miraculous gift of healing, as well as other gifts of the Holy Ghost, was often given with the sacraments, which were to be always continued, and not to cease, with those gifts. We may also take notice, that neither they who had this gift of healing, had any command or

advice to make use of it to all that were sick, nor were all that were sick ordered to seek for a cure of those who had this gift; whereas here S. James orders every one to send for the priests of the Church to anoint him, and pray over him for spiritual relief. S. Timothy had frequent infirmities, as we read 1 Tim. v. 23. nor yet did S. Paul, who had that gift, cure him. The same S. Paul left Trophimus sick at Miletum. 2 Tim. iv. 20.

Epaphroditus, S. Paul's companion in his labours, was sick, when he had S.

Paul with him, even unto death; that is, so as to be at the point of death (Philip.

ii. 27.); nor yet did S. Paul, but God, restore him to his health. And if S. James had spoken of a miraculous restoring of corporal health by that anointing, he should rather have said: bring in those who have the gift of healing; for we may reasonably suppose that many had this gift who were not priests, and we have no reason to suppose that all priests had this gift. Our adversaries tell us with great assurance, that this anointing mentioned by S. James was soon laid aside; which, say they, we may gather from the silence of the writers in the three following ages. To this merely negative argument the Catholics answer: 1. That it is enough we have the tradition and practise of the Church, witnessed by the writers in the ages immediately succeeding. 2. That the greatest part of the writings in those ages are not extant. 3. The writers of those times seldom mentioned those things which were sufficiently known among the Christians by daily use, especially what related to the sacraments and mysteries of the Christian religion, which (as it appears by the writings that they were able to preserve) they made it their particular endeavour to conceal from the heathens, who turned them to derision and contempt. In the mean time, had not this anointing been always retained and continued, the ages immediately following would not have conspired every where to practise it, and to look upon it as a sacrament. Not to insist on the authority of Origen,

[4] in the beginning of the third age, (hom. ii. in Levit.) who numbering up the different ways by which sins are forgiven in the new law, says,

that they were remitted when priests anoint the sick with oil, as in the epistle of S. James; S.

Chrys.[5] in the end of the fourth age, (in his third book de Sacerdotio, tom. i.

p. 384. Nov. Ed. Ben. written before the end of the fourth age, about the year 375) says, that priests (and his word expresseth sacrificing priests, not elders) have now a power to remit sins, which he proves from those words in S.

James, Is any man sick among you? &c. This shews, as do also Origen's words, that this custom was then continued in the East, in the Greek Church, and that it was believed a sacrament, of which the priests only were the ministers. Innocent I.[6] in his answers to Decentius, bishop of Eugenium, in Italy, at the beginning of the fifth age, an. 416, calls this anointing and prayer over the sick, set down in S. James' epistle, a sacrament in the same sense as other sacraments in the new law. See Labbe's Councils, tom. ii, p. 1248. And as to what Innocent I. and Ven. Bede relate of a custom by which lay persons, when a priest could not be had, anointed and prayed over a person in danger, it was only to testify their desire of having the sacrament: as it was likewise a pious custom in some places for sinners to make a confession to a layman, not that they then looked upon it as a sacrament, but only that they hoped God would accept of their private devotions and humiliation, when they could not have a priest to administer the sacraments to them. It is needless to mention authors in the following ages. S. Greg.

(Sacramentarium. fer. 5. in Cœna Dni.) describes the ceremony of blessing oil to be used in the anointing of the sick. Theodore, made archbishop of Canterbury, an. 668, among other decrees, ordains that sick persons receive the holy unction, set down by S.

James. The Capitularia of Charles the great, say that no one, when about to depart out of this world, ought to want the anointing of the sacrament of oil.

The same is ordained in a council of Chalons, an. 813, can. 48; by a council at Aix la Chapelle, an. 830, can. 5; by the council of Mayence,

an. 847, can. 26, &c.

Now since we find this anointing made use of as a sacrament at least from the fourth age, let our adversaries tell us when this anointing prescribed by S.

James was left off, and when and how it came to be taken up again. They have no manner of proofs for either; and yet we have a right, as the authors of the annotations on the Rhem. Testam. observe, to demand clear and convincing proofs in this case, when the Scripture seems so clear for us and against them. Dr. Fulk affirms boldly, that this anointing was never to this day received in the Greek Church as a sacrament. This only shews how little credit is to be given to him. He might have found great reason to doubt of his bold assertion, since neither Photius, in the ninth age, nor Michael Cerularius, in the eleventh, ever objected this difference betwixt their Greek and the Latin Church, at a time when they reckoned up even the most minute differences either in doctrine or discipline, so as to find fault with the Latins for shaving their beards. He might have found it by what happened at the time of the council of Lyons, in the thirteenth age, when the pope, in his letter to the emperor of Constantinople, wrote that the Latin Church, and all in communion with him, acknowledged seven sacraments, which the Greeks never blamed. He might have observed the same when the Greeks and Armenians came to an union in the council of Florence, in the fifteenth age. The same Dr. Fulk, who wrote about the year 1600, could scarce be ignorant of the ill success the Augsbourg confession met with among the Greeks, to whom, when the Lutherans had sent copies of their faith and of their reformation, Jeremy, the patriarch of Constantinople, with a synod of the Greeks, condemned their articles, and among other points, declared that they held "in the orthodox Catholic Church seven divine sacraments," the same as in the Latin Church, baptism . . . and the holy oil. Had Dr. Fulk lived a little longer, he must have been more and more ashamed to find other Greek synods condemning him and all the said reformers. For when Cyrillus Lucaris, advanced to the see of Constantinople by the interest of the French Calvinists, began to favour and support the doctrine of the Calvinists, the Greeks in several synods under their

patriarchs, (an. 1639, 1642, 1671, and 1672) condemned Cyril and the new doctrine of the said reformers, and expressly declared that they held seven sacraments. See M. Arnauld, tom. iii. *Perpetuité de la Foy*; and the dissertations of M. Le Brun, tom. iii. p. 34, and 572, disert. 12, where he shews that all the churches of the East, and all the Christian churches of the world, though separated from the communion and subordination to the Pope, agree with the Latin Church, as to the sacrifice of the Mass, as to the real presence of Christ in the Eucharist, and as to the seven sacraments. Wi. — If, with holy Scripture, we must allow that charitable persons on earth may prove instrumental, under God, to their neighbour's salvation, why are we to deny this to the saints in heaven, whose charity for man is much greater?

[1] V. 7. Temporaneum et Serotinum. In most Greek MSS. ueton proimon kai opsimon, pluviam priorem et posteriorem.

[2] V. 10. Exemplum accipite, exitus mali, et laboris, et patientiæ, kakopatheias kai makrothumias. There is nothing in the Greek for laboris, which the Latin interpreter may have added to express the full sense.

[3] V. 14-15. Infirmatur, asthenei tis; infirmum, kamnonta, laborantem; alleviabit, egerei, suscitabit.

[4] V. 20. Origen, in hom. ii, in Levit. p. 68. Ed. Par. an. 1574) where he numbers the different ways by which sins are remitted in the new law, and speaking of penance, says, In quo impletur et illud quod Apostolus dicit, Si quis autem infirmatur, vocet presbyteros ecclesiæ.

[5] Ibid. S. Chrys. iereis . . . echousin exousian, habent potestatem.

[6] Ibid. Innoc. I. Pœnitentibus istud infundi non potest, quia genus est Sacramenti, nam quibus reliqua Sacramenta negantur, quomodo unum genus putatur concedi? By charisma, Innocent I. understands, oleum ad unguendum.

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